

3 RH: When Bodhisattva Jofukyo 4 uttered to everyone he encountered his 24 character phrase, which we recite after Gongyo,⁵ “I respect you deeply, I do not despise you or look down on you with contempt, because everyone can become a Buddha, if they believe in Namumyōhōrengekyō⁶ and practice,” people thought he was weird and crazy, and felt uncomfortable in his presence. So they threw stones at him, beat him with sticks and staves, spit at him, demeaned and hurled insults at him, and ostracized him. And yet, for years upon years Bodhisattva Jofukyo continued to put his palms together and praise every person he encountered, despite their persecution of him. After a while, the people gradually began to realize that the way they were treating Jofukyo was not right. While on the other hand, Bodhisattva Jofukyo realized that in past lives he had behaved the same way as the people who were now persecuting him. He thought that what was happening to him was the result of actions and decisions he had made in the past. That is why he continued to praise every person he met. It is not a matter of a person who has no sense, or who is crazy, or who does bad things. In some way, everyone acts that way. For instance, when you say something or do something that you think is good for another person, it may not be a good thing. It may be your perception that your actions or your words are good, but they may not be. In that sense, what you think is good may be bad for the other person. In this life, just because you think you’ve done five good things and three bad things, and that the effects of the bad things will be erased because you did more good things, it doesn’t work that way. For the good things, accept them as the result of good deeds. And when bad things happen, also accept them, for there are reasons they came your way. In some circumstances, people might think, “Oh, I’ve done something wrong, so I can just apologize and be done with it.” But it doesn’t work that way either. After you make the apology, you have to live with the awareness that you did something in the past to bring this about. You take responsibility for and accept the results of your past actions, and in this life you change your behavior. B1: Is that what karma⁷ is? RH: Yes

4 Bodhisattva Jofukyo - Bodhisattva Fukyo – a bodhisattva described in the 20th chapter of the Lotus Sutra who revered everyone for their innate Buddha-nature, and was persecuted because of his compassionate behavior. 5 Gongyo – the practice of Nichiren Shoshu Buddhism which entails the morning and evening recitation of the 2nd and 16th chapters of the Lotus Sutra and chanting Namumyōhōrengekyō. 6 Namumyōhōrengekyō - the Mystic Law which enlightens all Buddhas; the Supreme Law of life and the universe; the Buddha-nature in all things. 7 Karma – thoughts, words and deeds which determine a person’s reality. Past thoughts, words and deeds influence the outcome in the present, just as present thoughts, words and deeds influence the outcome in the future.